

# Sheraden Community Council

## Executive Summary

### Client

Jonathan Alexander

### Student Consulting Team

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## Background

The Sheraden Community Council (SCC) is a nonprofit organization in Pittsburgh's West End focused on *improving the quality of life of Sheraden* through community engagement and volunteer-driven initiatives. Founded in 1968, SCC continues to organize neighborhood events with a volunteer-based team and limited funding. However, SCC does not have a standardized system for tracking volunteer participation, limiting outreach.

## Project Description

### Project Opportunity

The Sheraden Community Council faced challenges in collecting, managing, and utilizing volunteer data due to reliance on informal communication and manual tracking. These limitations led to incomplete records and limited visibility into participation, making it difficult to track engagement and enforce volunteer hour requirements. As a result, administrative time was spent on manual coordination rather than community-building efforts. Addressing these challenges would enable SCC to more effectively engage its members and better support the quality of life through active community participation.

### Project Vision

The vision for this system is to support the Sheraden Community Council's shift toward more meaningful member engagement by enabling the structured tracking of volunteer participation. In response to new eligibility requirements for voting members, the system provides a reliable way to manage volunteer activity while centralizing members' contact information through standardized forms. The system also tracks and validates volunteer hours to consistently enforce membership requirements. Ultimately, this solution prepares clean data for reporting and analysis and allows the SCC to independently manage the system, reducing administrative burden to supporting engagement and data-driven decision making.

## Project Outcomes

The project delivered outcomes across people, process, and technology within SCC:

- People
  - Administrators can perform mass communication and track member participation
  - Administrators can determine member eligibility without manual calculation
  - Board members can interpret participation data to inform decisions
  - Volunteers have to submit contact and participation information through forms
- Process

- Set up a formal workflow for reviewing & approving additional volunteer hours
- Standardized membership eligibility track to ensure consistent voting status
- Streamlined communication pipeline for mailing list management and engagement
- Technology
  - Google Forms that automates data collection
  - Google Sheets that store and visualize data
  - Google App Scripts that validate and normalize data, and automate email reporting
  - MailChimp integration for mass communication

## Project Deliverables

The deliverables for this project are organized within a centralized Google folder directory. This includes a suite of four Google forms for data entry and two raw data files that house the system's information. The primary output is a centralized dashboard, supported by custom code that integrates the components into a cohesive system. To ensure long-term usability, the directory also contains an operations manual, video tutorials, and technical diagrams that document the system's workflow and maintenance.

## Recommendations

To ensure the Sheraden Community Council's infrastructure remains scalable and secure, the system must prioritize administrative efficiency through an automated archiving dashboard that reduces search time for volunteer board members. Strengthening data governance involves decoupling contact management into a standalone, restricted registry using IMPORTRANGE to maintain "audit-ready" mailing lists without compromising sensitive dashboard data. Furthermore, implementing standardized input validation for geographic data, transitioning from open-text fields to dropdown menus, guarantees data integrity and precise neighborhood analysis. This "Low-Code, High-Impact" approach ensures the system remains a sustainable asset that is easily maintained by a volunteer-run organization while providing robust metrics for community engagement.

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## Student Consulting Team

**Jonathan Lai** served as project manager. He led the design, implementation, and transition of the components for tracking volunteer hours, the dashboard, and data workflows. He is a fourth-year student majoring in Information Systems with an additional major in Stat & ML. He will be a Data Engineering intern at Amazon and is looking toward a career in ML.

**Annabelle Wang** served as the client relationship manager. She coordinated the meeting logistics and led solution testing. She is a third-year student majoring in Information Systems with an additional major in Human-Computer Interaction and a minor in Artificial Intelligence. She will be interning at EY-Parthenon as a Software Strategy Consultant and is looking forward to a career in tech consulting and product management.

**Diana Cano** served as a developer. She led the design and implementation of the contact information components, like the Contact Form and MailChimp. She is a third-year student majoring in Information Systems with a minor in Animation & Special Effects. She will be conducting research this summer and is looking forward to a career exploring the cutting edge of entertainment technologies.